



VSM7

Lifecycle Extension

Concept 1.0

A cybernetic framework for Analysis, seven-step VSM Design, Before/After comparison, Deploy, Review, user access, and incremental product learning

FINAL REVIEW EDITION

Conceptual baseline - July 2026

Direction for an incremental product development journey

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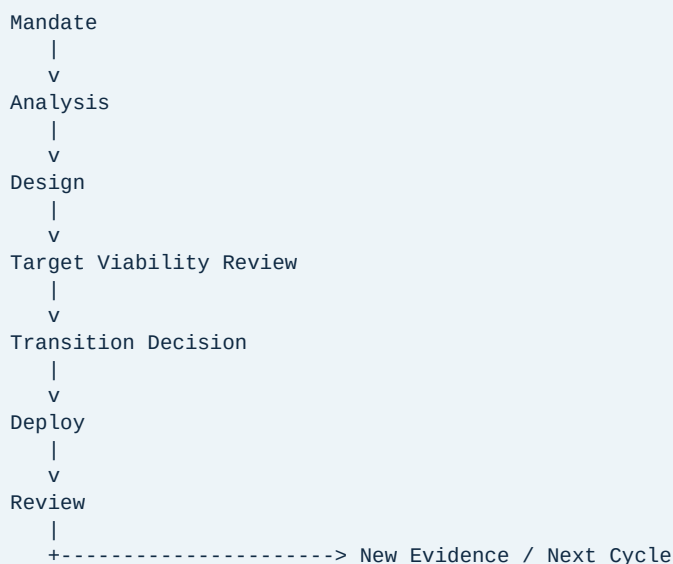
1. Executive Proposition

VSM7 currently provides substantial support for designing a viable organization through the seven VSM design steps. It also contains an initial Implementation area. What is missing is a coherent lifecycle around that design work.

The proposed extension adds:

- A Mandate that establishes purpose, scope, sponsorship, and intended effects.
- A deliberately lean Analysis Phase that establishes the current situation and Need for Change.
- A simple, scoped user and seat concept from technical Super-Admin to read-only View Seat.
- A persistent comparison between Before, Intended After, and Observed After.
- An integrative Target Viability Review at the close of Design.
- An explicit Transition Decision between Design and Deploy.
- A Deploy Phase that evolves the existing Implementation support.
- A Review Phase that observes results and returns them as new evidence.

The lifecycle is:



The Target Viability Review is a concluding Design control, not an eighth VSM design step. The Transition Decision is a decision gate, not a lifecycle phase, but it has a first-class product surface.

Six cross-phase capabilities accompany the lifecycle:

Compare | Evidence | Decisions | Traceability | Communication | Exports

The underlying cybernetic logic is:

```

Reference
-> Observation
-> Interpretation
-> Design
-> Comparison
-> Decision
-> Intervention
-> Feedback
-> Adaptation
  
```

VSM7 should therefore evolve from a sequence of design steps into a workshop environment that supports an ongoing organizational control loop.

This environment is used by different people for different purposes. Technical administration, organization administration, project management, workshop facilitation, content editing, viewing, and organizational decision authority must be distinguished. Access to a screen never substitutes for legitimate authority to change decision rights, accountability, resources, or policy.

This concept is not a promise to build the entire model at once. It is a directional baseline for an incremental product development journey. Each product increment must deliver useful workshop capability, produce evidence from real use, and inform the next increment.

The development of VSM7 should itself operate as a learning loop:

```
Concept
-> Product Increment
-> Workshop Use
-> Evidence
-> Product Finding
-> Product Decision
-> Next Increment
```

The concept is the start of the journey, not a frozen prediction of the final product.

2. Purpose and Product Boundary

The extension should enable a VSM7 project to answer five distinct questions.

Mandate

Why are we undertaking this inquiry, and what should become possible?

Analysis

What is happening in the current system, and why does it matter?

Design

What viable system should exist?

Deploy

How will the organization move toward the authorized design?

Review

What actually changed, and did the original situation improve?

The extension must remain a VSM workshop capability. It must not turn VSM7 into:

- A generic transformation-management platform.
- A comprehensive process repository.
- A general document-management system.
- An automated organizational diagnosis engine.
- A substitute for VSM expertise and facilitator judgment.
- A waterfall project method that assumes Analysis, Design, and change occur only once.

The application remains the canonical workshop record. External whiteboards, meeting platforms, and office documents may support collaboration, but consolidated project evidence, findings, design artifacts, decisions, and deployment work belong in VSM7.

The product must remain simple enough to share with stakeholders who only need a browser and a View Seat. Its user model must support controlled participation without forcing every observer, sponsor, or reviewer into an editor role.

3. Cybernetic Interpretation

A control loop requires:

- A reference condition or intended effect.
- Observation of the current system.
- An interpretation of relevant conditions.
- A model of the desired system.
- Detection of meaningful differences.
- Selection of a response.
- Intervention in the system.
- Feedback about actual effects.
- Adaptation when the intervention does not produce the intended result.

The VSM7 lifecycle provides corresponding capabilities:

Cybernetic function	VSM7 capability
Reference condition	Mandate and intended effects
Observation	Evidence and Current-State Snapshot
Interpretation	Findings and viability tensions
Desired-system model	VSM Design Steps I-VII
Coherence control	Target Viability Review
Comparator	Before / Intended After / Observed After
Selection and authorization	Decision Records and Transition Decision
Intervention	Deployment Items and waves
Feedback	Initiative Review, System Review, and stakeholder response
Adaptation	New findings, renewed decisions, design revision, and re-baselining

This is a cybernetic interpretation of the project lifecycle. It is not a literal one-to-one assignment of each project phase to one VSM system.

The lifecycle must nevertheless remain recognizably grounded in VSM logic. It pays particular attention to:

- System identity and purpose.
- System-in-Focus.
- Recursion.
- Operative autonomy.
- Coordination.
- Resource and performance control.
- Independent verification through S3*.
- Environmental intelligence.
- Policy and normative closure.
- Variety attenuation and amplification.
- Communication channels and closed loops.
- Algedonic escalation.

- Recursive learning.

4. Structural Vocabulary

4.1 Lifecycle Phases

The lifecycle phases are:

```
Mandate -> Analysis -> Design -> Deploy -> Review
```

The Target Viability Review concludes Design. The Transition Decision authorizes or declines movement from Design into Deploy.

4.2 Cross-Phase Capabilities

The following are not lifecycle phases:

- Compare
- Evidence
- Decisions
- Traceability
- Communication
- Exports

Compare may appear prominently in navigation because it is an important working surface. It is not an eighth VSM method step or an additional intervention phase.

4.3 Three Organizational States

The familiar phrase "Before/After" is useful but ambiguous. VSM7 must distinguish three states.

Before

The current-state baseline established during Analysis.

Intended After

The target state produced during Design and tested in the Target Viability Review.

Observed After

The organizational reality observed after deployment activity.

Before Deploy, the comparison is primarily:

```
Before <-> Intended After
```

After Deploy, the full comparison becomes:

```
Before <-> Intended After <-> Observed After
```

An accepted target design must never automatically become the next Before. Only observed and deliberately re-baselined organizational reality can become the baseline of a new cycle.

5. Mandate

5.1 Purpose

The Mandate establishes the reference conditions for the inquiry. It defines why the project exists without prematurely prescribing the organizational solution.

5.2 Mandate Content

The Mandate captures:

- Trigger for the project.
- Project purpose.
- Sponsor.
- Named decision authority where already known.
- Preliminary System-in-Focus.
- Relevant environment.
- Preliminary scope.
- Participants and stakeholder groups.
- Important assumptions.
- Constraints and non-negotiables.
- Decisions the project should enable.
- Intended effects.
- Observable signals of improvement.
- Review horizon.
- Conditions requiring escalation or renewed authorization.

Intended effects are reference signals, not completion percentages or promises of causality.

Examples include:

- Operational decisions can be taken at the appropriate recursion level.
- Senior management spends less time resolving routine operational exceptions.
- Strategic intelligence influences resource and priority decisions.
- Critical end-to-end work has identifiable accountability.
- Important control loops no longer depend exclusively on personal relationships.
- Independent verification is available where formal reports and operating reality may diverge.

Later System Review asks whether these decision capabilities and observable conditions actually moved.

5.3 System-in-Focus as Hypothesis

The initial System-in-Focus is provisional. Analysis may reveal that:

- The boundary is too narrow.
- The boundary is too broad.
- The relevant tension belongs at a higher recursion level.
- Important operative units lie outside the original scope.
- Required participants are missing.
- The mandate does not provide authority to address the diagnosed issue.

At the close of Analysis, the System-in-Focus passes through an explicit checkpoint.

Possible outcomes are:

- Confirm the original System-in-Focus.
- Revise the boundary within the existing mandate.
- Reconfirm scope and participation with the sponsor.
- Escalate a finding to a higher recursion level.
- Create a linked inquiry for another recursive system.
- Stop because the actual issue exceeds the mandate.

5.4 Stakeholder Groups

Stakeholder groups are established in the Mandate with stable identities. The same groups can then be referenced by:

- Analysis perspectives.
- Contested findings.
- Design participation.
- Stakeholder impacts.
- Communication activities.
- Stakeholder responses.
- Deployment Items.
- Reviews.

A stakeholder group is distinct from an artifact owner. An owner may be a named person or organizational role.

5.5 Relationship to the Existing Product

The existing Project Frame becomes the foundation of the Mandate rather than being duplicated. Existing information about purpose, customers, and the System-in-Focus can seed it.

Project Overview becomes a read-mostly lifecycle dashboard showing, over time:

- Current phase.
- Current System-in-Focus.
- Latest baseline date.
- Important open findings.
- Major decisions.
- Transition status.
- Upcoming reviews.

6. Analysis

6.1 Purpose

Analysis creates a sufficiently credible understanding of the current system to begin responsible design.

Its central question is:

What is happening in the current system, why does it matter, and what must Design address?

Analysis must remain deliberately lean. It is not intended to become:

- A complete organizational audit.
- A comprehensive process inventory.
- A duplicate of the seven Design steps.
- A generic current-state consulting study.
- An automated organizational diagnosis.
- A hidden target-design exercise.

6.2 Analysis Structure

Analysis contains four compact areas:

1. Analysis Frame.
2. Current-State Snapshot.
3. Findings.
4. Need for Change and Design Brief.

6.3 Analysis Frame

The Analysis Frame translates the Mandate into a focused inquiry. It captures:

- Questions to be answered.
- Relevant System-in-Focus hypothesis.
- Relevant recursion levels.
- Stakeholder perspectives.
- Evidence sources.
- Time horizon.
- Assumptions.
- Known constraints.
- Areas explicitly outside the inquiry.

The frame protects Analysis from becoming an unlimited collection exercise.

6.4 Current-State Snapshot

The Current-State Snapshot is the lean Before baseline. It records addressable statements about current reality rather than reconstructing a complete second VSM design.

Relevant areas may include:

- Identity and purpose.
- Environment.
- Customers and beneficiaries.

- Products, services, and value creation.
- Current operative organization.
- Existing recursion.
- Operational variety.
- Important dependencies.
- Decision-making.
- Coordination.
- Resource negotiation.
- Performance control.
- Independent verification and audit through S3*.
- Environmental intelligence.
- Policy and normative direction.
- Formal and informal communication channels.
- Recurring escalations.
- Existing strengths and successful coping mechanisms.

A distinction is maintained between:

- **Formal reality:** what structures, policies, responsibilities, and organization charts prescribe.
- **Operating reality:** how work, communication, coordination, and decisions actually occur.

A Baseline Statement may be:

- Known.
- Unknown.
- Disputed.

It may describe:

- Formal reality.
- Operating reality.
- Both.
- A mismatch between the two.

Uncertainty is legitimate evidence. VSM7 must not force workshop participants to manufacture certainty.

Snapshot topics that are irrelevant to the Mandate may be explicitly skipped. The snapshot is a synopsis, not an organizational inventory.

6.5 VSM-Based Interpretation Without Premature Design

The snapshot may be interpreted through VSM lenses, but current reality must not be forced into an artificially tidy S1-S5 diagram.

During enrichment, a Finding may be associated with one or more of:

- S1 operations and autonomy.
- S2 coordination.
- S3 control, optimization, and resource negotiation.
- S3* independent verification.
- S4 environmental intelligence and future orientation.

- S5 identity, policy, and normative closure.
- A specific communication channel.
- A recursion level.
- A relationship between recursion levels.
- The complete System-in-Focus.
- An unresolved or unclear systemic location.

This systemic locator supports interpretation and later clustering. It does not manufacture precision. A Finding may relate to several systems, channels, or recursion levels.

6.6 Evidence, Baseline Statements, and Findings

These concepts remain distinct.

Evidence Reference

A relevant source that can support or challenge a Baseline Statement, Finding, Decision Record, or Observed Outcome.

Examples include:

- Interview note.
- Workshop statement.
- Document reference.
- Meeting observation.
- Decision record.
- Process evidence.
- Existing metric.
- Stakeholder Response.
- Review result.

VSM7 stores or references only evidence that is relevant to a project statement, finding, decision, or outcome. It does not become a general document-management repository.

Baseline Statement

An addressable statement about current formal or operating reality.

Example:

Nine of twelve sampled operational exceptions were escalated to senior management.

Finding

A human-authored interpretation of one or more Baseline Statements and Evidence References.

Example:

Local decision authority and escalation conditions are unclear, causing routine variety to be absorbed at a higher recursion level.

Viability tension is a Finding type, not a separate canonical artifact.

Findings are workshop judgments. They are never presented as automatically proven organizational truth.

6.7 Capture First, Enrich Later

Live workshop capture must be fast. An initial Finding may require only:

- Short title.

- Observation or interpretation.
- One relevant tag or scope reference.

Additional information can be added after the immediate workshop moment:

- Evidence References.
- Affected scope.
- Stakeholder perspectives.
- Systemic locator.
- Consequence.
- Existing strength or compensating mechanism.
- Severity.
- Confidence.
- Status.
- What would resolve uncertainty.
- Design hypothesis or question.

A visible enrichment queue may identify Findings requiring further work.

Exact text limits, field counts, and work-in-progress limits should be tested through workshop use. They are product hypotheses, not immutable method rules.

6.8 Finding Status and Disagreement

The canonical Finding collection is cross-phase. Every Finding records its phase of origin, such as Analysis, Design, Deploy, or Review.

Findings support at least these conceptual states:

- Draft.
- Agreed.
- Contested.
- Parked.

A Contested Finding captures:

- Differing interpretations.
- Stakeholders associated with each perspective.
- Evidence supporting each position.
- What could resolve the disagreement.
- Whether an experiment or independent S3* check is appropriate.

Disagreement is not the same as weak confidence. Two stakeholders may hold opposing positions with high confidence. The disagreement itself may reveal a coordination, control, or verification failure.

Confidence and severity therefore remain separate.

6.9 Need for Change

The Need for Change is the principal communicative outcome of Analysis. It explains:

- Why action is being considered.
- Why action is relevant now.
- Which aspects of the current system are under pressure.

- What happens if nothing changes.
- Which strengths must be preserved.
- What the organization must become capable of doing.
- What remains uncertain.

It does not prescribe the target organization.

The phase distinction is:

Analysis: Why must something change?
 Design: What should change?
 Compare: Who and what would be affected?
 Deploy: How will authorized change be realized?
 Review: What changed in reality?

6.10 Design Brief

The Design Brief translates Analysis into questions and constraints for the seven VSM design steps. It includes:

- Priority Findings.
- Strengths to preserve.
- Design questions.
- Design hypotheses.
- Constraints.
- Unresolved tensions.
- Areas requiring experimentation.
- Matters outside the current mandate.
- Findings pointing to another recursion level.

"Design hypothesis" is used where Analysis has not justified a specific solution. During Design, a hypothesis may be accepted, modified, rejected, partially addressed, or deliberately left unresolved.

6.11 Analysis Boundaries

Analysis does not:

- Select the final segmentation.
- Define the final recursion structure.
- Produce the definitive SCT set.
- Allocate final central and decentralized responsibilities.
- Assign SCT contributions to VSM systems.
- Design target communication loops.
- Define target roles or meetings.
- Produce the final transformation backlog.

Analysis may identify tensions in these areas, but the corresponding decisions belong in Design.

Example:

Analysis Finding:
 Routine decisions are unnecessarily escalated.

Decision Record originating in Design:
 Defined decision categories are allocated to the relevant operative units.

Delta:
 Authority moves closer to operations while explicit escalation conditions are introduced.

Deployment Item:
Decision guidelines, role changes, and review practices are introduced.

6.12 Analysis Sufficiency and Closure

Analysis is sufficiently mature when there is reasonable agreement about:

- The System-in-Focus or the need to revise it.
- Important environmental pressures.
- Existing strengths.
- Priority viability tensions.
- The Need for Change.
- Relevant uncertainties.
- Questions Design must answer.

No phase or step completeness percentage is calculated. The facilitator decides whether the baseline is sufficiently credible to support Design.

Analysis closes through:

- System-in-Focus checkpoint.
- Acceptance of the Need for Change and Design Brief.
- Locking of the current baseline version.

7. Baseline Lifecycle

7.1 One Project, Not Two Workspaces

The Before does not become a duplicate VSM workspace.

One project contains:

- A lean Analysis Baseline.
- Live canonical Design artifacts.
- Links between them.
- Later observations of realized reality.

The baseline contains addressable statements. The target side references canonical VSM7 entities such as:

- Organizational units.
- Recursion entries.
- SCTs.
- SCT Contributions.
- VSM systems.
- Communication loops.
- E2E routes.
- Roles.
- Meetings.
- Accountabilities.

Canonical target artifacts are referenced through stable identities rather than copied into comparison records.

7.2 Baseline Lock

The baseline remains editable during Analysis. When the Design Brief is accepted:

- The baseline is locked.
- Its date and version remain visible.
- Design begins against that explicit baseline.

This does not imply that organizational reality stops changing. It ensures that comparisons retain meaning.

7.3 Re-Baselining

If current reality changes materially during a long design process, a human may re-baseline.

Re-baselining:

- Creates a new baseline version.
- Preserves the previous version.
- Records why the baseline changed.
- Flags affected Deltas for review.
- Never silently rewrites historical reasoning.

Every comparison shows the baseline version and age against which it was created.

7.4 Next-Cycle Baseline

After Deploy and Review, Observed After may become the baseline for a new cycle.

The new baseline is based on sufficiently credible observations and an explicit re-baselining decision. It is not created by copying the Intended After.

8. Design

8.1 Purpose

Design answers:

What viable system should exist?

The existing VSM Steps I-VII are the core Design Phase. They transform the Need for Change and Design Brief into an integrated Intended After.

The Design Phase is not a black box between Analysis and Deploy. It is the methodical center of VSM7:

1. Operative Units.
2. Manageability.
3. SCTs.
4. Central/Decentral.
5. Design Steering System.
6. Channels.
7. Representation.

Together they answer:

Step	Central design question	Principal outcome
I. Operative Units	What should constitute the System-in-Focus and its value-producing operative units?	Target boundary, recursion, segmentation, and selected operative model

Step	Central design question	Principal outcome
II. Manageability	Can relevant variety be handled, and where must it be attenuated or amplified?	Manageability assessment and required remedies
III. SCTs	What must permanently be done for viability and strategic success?	Canonical Success-Critical Tasks
IV. Central/Decentral	Where are SCT Contributions required, and where should authority reside?	Contributions by unit and recursion level, with subsidiarity decisions
V. Design Steering System	Which VSM function performs each R0/SIF contribution?	Target allocation across S1-S5, including S3*
VI. Channels	How must work and information circulate through robust closed loops?	E2E routes and communication-variety checks
VII. Representation	Who is accountable, involved, connected, and represented?	Vessels, RASIC, roles, meetings, accountability, and representation

8.2 A Recursive Design Process

The seven steps have a sequence, but the design process is not strictly linear.

```
Operative structure
-> Variety and manageability
-> Success-Critical Tasks
-> Contributions and authority
-> Steering functions
-> Communication loops
-> Accountability and representation
    ^
    +--- evidence and contradictions may return the design upstream
```

Examples of legitimate return loops include:

- Step II reveals that a Step I segmentation creates unmanageable variety.
- Step IV reveals that one SCT contains several fundamentally different contributions and should be split in Step III.
- Step V reveals that a contribution appears to serve several VSM systems and requires upstream decomposition.
- Step VI reveals a route that cannot be made robust with the current contribution or recursion design.
- Step VII reveals accountability that cannot be assigned coherently because an earlier authority decision remains unresolved.

Returning upstream does not erase the earlier reasoning. The relevant Decision Records, Findings, and Design Responses remain visible.

8.3 Relationship to Analysis

Analysis provides:

- Findings.
- Existing strengths.
- Design questions.
- Design hypotheses.
- Constraints.
- Systemic tensions.
- Evidence References.

Design creates:

- Target operative units.
- Target recursion.
- Canonical SCTs.

- SCT Contributions.
- Central and decentralized allocations.
- VSM-system assignments.
- Communication routes and loops.
- Roles.
- Meetings.
- Accountability.
- Representation.

The distinction remains explicit:

Analysis	Design
Describes current operative reality	Selects target operative units
Observes current recursion	Defines intended recursion
Identifies critical responsibilities	Defines canonical SCTs
Observes authority and escalation	Allocates target decision rights
Observes steering capabilities	Designs the target steering system
Identifies communication weaknesses	Designs target channels
Observes roles and meetings	Defines target accountability and representation

Analysis describes the Before and defines design questions. Design creates the Intended After. Design must preserve strengths identified in Analysis as deliberately as it addresses tensions.

8.4 Shared Design Controls

The following controls apply across all seven steps:

- R0/System-in-Focus is the default workshop lens.
- Other recursion levels remain available through explicit scope controls and visible grouping.
- Canonical entities are referenced by stable identity rather than copied text.
- Human-readable display ids and names are shown instead of internal identifiers.
- Suggestions, derived material, and diagnostic signals never become organizational truth without human confirmation.
- Human-authored decisions are never silently overwritten by regenerated or upstream-derived content.
- Consequential choices may carry a Decision Record.
- Findings remain linked through Design Responses.
- Empty or unresolved fields are visible; no completeness percentage is calculated.
- Business and support functions are treated consistently. The facilitator applies the relevant VSM distinction between operative and support activity.
- Every destructive action names the affected artifact and requires confirmation.

8.5 Step I: Operative Units

Design question

What is the System-in-Focus, how is it recursively embedded, and which segmentation best creates relatively autonomous value-producing units?

Inputs

- Mandate and System-in-Focus hypothesis.
- Analysis Baseline and current boundary statements.
- Customers, beneficiaries, products, and services.
- Environmental variety and relevant Findings.
- Strengths and constraints from the Design Brief.

Core design work

Step I contains five connected areas:

1. **System-in-Focus and Recursion Levels.** Confirm the target SIF, its containing system, and its lower-level viable systems. Recursion-level labels remain fixed; users define the names and descriptions of the systems occupying those levels. Additional systems may exist on the same level.
2. **Segmentation Options.** Develop plausible ways to segment operative units, such as by customer, product, geography, service, or another value-relevant distinction. The current organization is an input, not the default target.
3. **Key Buying Criteria.** Define customer-facing purchase-deciding criteria, normally five to seven, with weights totaling 100 percent. Relative Position is expressed as Relative Position to Competition.
4. **Strategic Fields of Action.** Use the Six Pack of Control to record priorities, targets, ambitions, supporting evidence, files, and links.
5. **Evaluation.** Compare segmentation options through forced prioritization. For n options, each criterion row uses $1 \dots n+1$, and a numeric score may appear only once per row. Column sums support the decision without replacing human judgment.

Canonical outcome

- Confirmed target System-in-Focus.
- Target recursion structure and organizational units with stable identities.
- Segmentation options and their rationale.
- Weighted Key Buying Criteria.
- Strategic Fields of Action.
- Selected segmentation option and Decision Record.

The selected segmentation becomes the structural foundation for subsequent steps.

Before/After contribution

Step I compares the current practical boundary and organization with the intended system boundary, recursion, and operative segmentation. Typical Deltas include retain, split, merge, introduce, reposition, and retire.

Return conditions

Return to Analysis or the Mandate when the System-in-Focus no longer matches the problem. Revisit Step I when Step II exposes unmanageable variety or later steps reveal that the chosen units cannot sustain meaningful autonomy.

8.6 Step II: Manageability

Design question

Can the selected operative structure absorb the variety it faces without overloading higher-level steering, and what remedies are required?

Inputs

- Selected Step I segmentation and recursion.

- Environmental and operational variety from Analysis.
- Existing escalation, coordination, control, and S3* verification patterns.
- Key Buying Criteria and strategic priorities.

Core design work

Step II examines the relationship between horizontal variety in and between operative units and the vertical variety available to coordinate, control, verify, and orient them.

The workshop considers:

- Similarity and difference between operative units.
- Variety entering from customers and local environments.
- Coordination load between S1 units.
- Resource and performance-control load on S3.
- Availability of independent S3* information.
- Strategic and normative load on S4 and S5.
- Unnecessary recursion levels or avoidable escalation.
- Variety attenuation, amplification, re-clustering, and channel-strengthening remedies.

Assessments, sliders, or visual balances support conversation. They are not automatic proof that the organization is manageable.

Canonical outcome

- Manageability assessment of the selected target structure.
- Explicit variety tensions.
- Remedy hypotheses.
- Design constraints for SCTs, authority, systems, and channels.
- Findings requiring a Step I revision.

Before/After contribution

Step II explains how the Intended After should handle variety differently from the Before, including which variety moves locally, which is attenuated, which requires amplification, and which still needs escalation.

Return conditions

Return to Step I when the segmentation or recursion creates structural overload. Carry unresolved manageability assumptions into the Target Viability Review and, where appropriate, into controlled deployment experiments.

8.7 Step III: Success-Critical Tasks

Desian question

What must permanently be done so that the System-in-Focus remains viable and succeeds in its environment?

Inputs

- Analysis Findings and Need for Change.
- Step I strategic fields, Key Buying Criteria, and weak evaluation signals.
- Step II variety tensions and remedies.
- Environmental intelligence and strategic obligations.

Core design work

The workshop defines Success-Critical Tasks as persistent organizational responsibilities, not temporary project actions or generic department labels.

Potential SCTs may be prompted by Analysis or weak design signals, but they become canonical only through human definition and acceptance.

Each SCT should be sufficiently distinct to support later contribution, system, channel, and accountability decisions. If one SCT appears to require incompatible purposes or several VSM-system allocations at the same contribution, it should be decomposed rather than stretched.

SCT split and merge operations preserve traceability through stable references and explicit rewiring. They do not create disconnected copies for later steps.

Canonical outcome

- Canonical SCT register with stable ids and readable display ids.
- SCT name, description, rationale, and relevant source context.
- Priority or attention signals where the workshop uses them.
- Split, merge, or decomposition decisions.

Before/After contribution

Step III compares current critical responsibilities, including unclear or fragmented work, with an explicit set of permanent target responsibilities.

Return conditions

Return to Step III when Step IV cannot describe coherent contributions or Step V finds that a contribution would need assignment to several systems. New evidence may add, split, merge, or retire an SCT, but all downstream references require controlled reconciliation.

8.8 Step IV: Central/Decentral

Design question

Which organizational units at which recursion levels contribute to each SCT, and where should responsibility and authority reside under subsidiarity?

Inputs

- Canonical SCTs from Step III.
- Actual recursion levels and units from Step I.
- Step II variety and manageability constraints.
- Current authority patterns and relevant Analysis Findings.

Core design work

Step IV creates an SCT Contribution at each meaningful intersection of:

- Canonical SCT.
- Recursion-level entry.
- Organizational unit represented by that entry.

Every intersection provides a free-text contribution description. An empty field means no contribution has been identified; it does not imply that the system has proved none exists.

The workshop applies subsidiarity:

- Keep work and authority decentralized where the operative unit can absorb the relevant variety.
- Centralize only where a genuine synergy, coherence, risk, or shared capability requires it.

- Do not damage customer value or operative autonomy merely to simplify the formal structure.
- Make escalation and accountability conditions explicit.

Step IV uses the actual Step I units. It never substitutes generic R-1, R0, and R+1 columns for the organizational systems occupying those levels.

Canonical outcome

- Persistent SCT Contributions linked to canonical SCTs and Step I units.
- Contribution descriptions by recursion and unit.
- Accountable organizational-unit anchors where required.
- Central/decentral and subsidiarity decisions.
- Unresolved authority questions requiring a Decision Record or escalation.

Before/After contribution

Step IV exposes changes in responsibility, authority, recursion, and the location where variety is absorbed. Decision-rights Deltas later require confirmation from the holder or grantor of the relevant authority.

Return conditions

Return to Step III when a contribution cannot be expressed coherently. Return to Step I when required contributions expose a missing or incorrectly bounded operative unit. Renaming or moving a Step I unit preserves Contributions through stable identity. Removing a referenced unit never silently deletes downstream contribution evidence.

8.9 Step V: Design Steering System

Desian question

Which VSM steering function performs each real R0/System-in-Focus SCT Contribution?

Inputs

- Real, non-empty R0/SIF SCT Contributions from Step IV.
- Step II manageability assessment.
- Canonical VSM systems and the recursion context.
- Analysis Findings about current steering capabilities.

Core design work

Step V is a system-first, one-to-one mapping workflow:

1. Select a VSM system in the code-native VSM diagram.
2. Assign the actual R0/SIF Contributions that perform that function.
3. Review mapped Contributions grouped by system.
4. Keep unmapped Contributions visible.

Each Contribution is assigned to exactly one VSM system. If it appears to serve several systems, the Contribution or its SCT must be decomposed upstream.

The mapping distinguishes:

- A doctrinal lens in which S2-S5 are the steering systems and S1 remains self-organizing.
- A pragmatic lens in which S1 may be mapped when the R0 Contribution describes operative work.

S3* remains a distinct system and channel of independent verification. It must never disappear into S3.

The interactive VSM visual is code-native, recursion-aware, and faithful to the VSM colour and shape grammar. It is available both within Step V and as a standalone main-navigation capability.

Canonical outcome

- One VSM-system assignment per mapped R0/SIF Contribution.
- Visible unmapped Contributions.
- Distribution of mapped Contributions across systems.
- Human-led comparison with the Step II variety assessment.
- Findings or upstream decomposition requests.

Distribution patterns and gaps are workshop signals, not automatic organizational truth. Roles, meetings, and RASIC do not belong in Step V.

Before/After contribution

Step V compares existing steering capabilities with the explicit target functions that will perform the System-in-Focus Contributions.

Return conditions

Return to Step III or IV when a Contribution cannot receive one coherent system assignment. Return to Step II when the target distribution suggests unresolved control overload or insufficient intelligence, policy, coordination, or independent verification.

8.10 Step VI: Channels

Design question

How must work and information flow so that SCTs are delivered and the VSM communication loops carry sufficient variety?

Step VI has two distinct but connected scopes.

6.1 E2E Process Robustness Check

The E2E route describes the **HOW** of delivering a primary SCT's **WHAT**.

The workshop:

- Selects one primary SCT.
- May explicitly include related SCTs where a real process crosses SCT boundaries.
- Uses actual Step IV Contributions as context.
- Builds a route from a user-defined Trigger to a Result.
- Places steps in read-only recursion lanes derived from Step I.
- Connects steps and makes lane crossings visible.
- Captures context and hand-off observations through call-outs.
- Records structured Findings on route steps or connections.

The route is human-authored. The tool may expose neutral facts such as crossings, unreachable results, or missing links, but it does not automatically declare the route robust or fragile.

Related-SCT removal never deletes placed route evidence. Source references remain and are visibly marked unavailable.

6.2 Communication Variety Checks

Every System-in-Focus receives the fixed canonical vertical-loop checklist:

1. S5-S1 algedonic communication.
2. S3-S1 command.
3. S3-S1 resource bargain.
4. S3*-S1 audit.

5. S2-S1 coordination.
6. S4-S3 homeostat.
7. S5-S4/S3 normative communication.

Missing or informal loops remain visible because absence is a diagnostic result.

Each loop is considered through four fixed channel criteria:

- Capacity.
- Clarity.
- Synchronicity.
- Feedback and closure of the loop.

The workshop records how the loop is carried through communication, meetings, artifacts, roles, and observations. A live VSM may highlight the selected loop, but the ratings and interpretation remain human-led.

Canonical outcome

- E2E routes keyed to their primary SCT.
- Stable references to related SCTs and Contributions.
- Transition call-outs and route Findings.
- Per-SIF communication-loop assessments.
- Communication, artifact, and role observations per loop.
- Explicit missing or weak channels.

Step VI Findings become Deploy candidates only through explicit human promotion. The source {routeId, findingId} or {loopId, criterion} remains attached.

Before/After contribution

Step VI compares current hand-offs and communication loops with the intended closed-loop routes and channel capabilities.

Return conditions

Return to Step IV when required Contributions or recursion placement are missing. Return to Step V when a steering function lacks a credible channel. Return to Step III when a route exposes an incoherent SCT boundary.

8.11 Step VII: Representation

Design question

Who is accountable and involved, through which roles and meetings, and how should the designed system be represented without losing its SCT and VSM logic?

Inputs

- Canonical SCTs and Contributions.
- Step IV accountability anchors.
- Step V system assignments.
- Step VI E2E routes and communication loops.
- Step I units and recursion.

Core design work

Step VII enriches the same canonical SCT and Contribution spine:

```
SCT
-> SCT Contribution
-> RASIC Assignment
-> Organizational Vessel
```


-> Role, Function, Meeting, and Representation

Its seven working areas are:

1. **Vessels.** Establish canonical roles, functions, and meetings with stable identities, scope, provenance, and candidate or accepted state.
2. **RASIC.** Assign Responsible, Accountable, Supporting, Informed, and Consulted relationships per SCT Contribution and vessel. R0/SIF Contributions are the default view; other levels remain explicitly accessible.
3. **Metrics, Artifacts, and Tools.** Attach optional reusable definitions and result types to SCTs without making empty sections invalid.
4. **Roles.** Define purpose, interfaces, meetings, and inherited or role-specific metrics, artifacts, and tools.
5. **Functions.** Apply the same derive-and-refine logic to functions.
6. **Meetings and Agendas.** Design meeting charters, participation, cadence, inputs, decisions, outputs, tools, metrics, decision rights, communication-loop support, escalation, and the meeting landscape.
7. **Organizational Representation.** Present recursion, units, functions, roles, meetings, RASIC, and VSM context through a code-native hierarchy and other projections.

Vessels are system-agnostic. Their VSM-system meaning comes from the SCT Contributions they serve, not from a copied system field.

Step VII follows derive-then-refine:

- Reuse canonical entries before creating new ones.
- Show derived suggestions with provenance.
- Require human ratification before treating suggestions as accepted organization design.
- Never silently overwrite human-authored content when the upstream graph changes.
- Offer a visible diff or review of regenerated material.

Warnings such as no Accountable vessel, multiple Accountable vessels, or responsibility without accountability invite decisions. They do not block the workshop or become completeness scores.

Where the hierarchy is authored, its parent/child relation is canonical design data. Visual layout, overlays, collapse state, and alternative projections remain views. Moving a box cannot remove or conceal its accountability warnings.

Canonical outcome

- Canonical vessel registry.
- RASIC relationships per SCT Contribution.
- Reusable metric, artifact, and tool definitions and local uses.
- Role and function descriptions.
- Meeting charters, participation, cadence, and communication relationships.
- Accountability and escalation arrangements.
- Canonical hierarchy where explicitly authored.
- Organizational representations linked back to SCTs and Contributions.

Before/After contribution

Step VII compares current roles, meetings, decision relationships, and hierarchy with the target accountability and representation of the designed viable system.

Return conditions

Return to Step IV when accountable authority cannot be located coherently. Return to Step V or VI when a role or meeting lacks a clear steering function or communication-loop purpose. Return to Step III when representation exposes a missing permanent responsibility.

8.12 Cross-Step Change Control

When an upstream canonical artifact changes, downstream work is reviewed rather than silently regenerated.

Upstream change	Downstream treatment
Step I unit renamed or moved	Preserve references by stable id and update visible labels
Step I unit removed	Confirm impact; retain or flag affected Contributions and route evidence
SCT renamed	Resolve the name live from the canonical SCT
SCT split	Create a new SCT identity and rewire selected Contributions and evidence explicitly
SCT merge	Keep one identity, rewire valid references, preserve detached evidence
Contribution changed	Flag affected mappings, routes, RASIC, and Design Responses for review
VSM assignment changed	Reassess relevant channels, roles, meetings, and representations
Loop or route evidence removed	Keep derived Deploy work and mark its source detached
RASIC or hierarchy changed	Recompute warnings without erasing human decisions

8.13 Design Outputs as the Intended After

The Intended After is not one diagram. It is the integrated target model produced by all seven steps:

- Target System-in-Focus and recursion.
- Operative segmentation.
- Manageability assumptions and remedies.
- Canonical SCTs.
- SCT Contributions by unit and recursion.
- Central/decentral and authority decisions.
- VSM-system assignments.
- E2E routes and communication loops.
- Roles, functions, meetings, RASIC, hierarchy, and representation.
- Design Responses, Decision Records, unresolved Findings, and assumptions.

Compare uses this integrated model against the lean Analysis Baseline. The Target Viability Review examines it as a coherent whole.

8.14 Design Responses

A lightweight Design Response connects a Finding to a canonical target artifact.

It records:

- Finding or Findings being addressed.
- Target artifact.
- Response stance.
- Short rationale.

Possible stances are:

- Addresses.
- Partially addresses.
- Deliberately does not address.
- Requires another design decision.
- Outside the current design scope.

A Finding may have several Design Responses, and one target artifact may respond to several Findings.

8.15 Decision Records

Consequential choices support a concise Decision Record containing, where relevant:

- Decision.
- Alternatives considered.
- Rationale.
- Relevant Findings.
- Affected target artifacts.
- Decision owner.
- Date.
- Conditions.
- Review trigger.

Not every workshop selection requires a formal Decision Record. The artifact is intended for consequential, contested, or conditional decisions whose reasoning should remain visible.

8.16 VSM Integrity

The target design preserves established VSM7 method boundaries:

- SCTs remain canonical entities.
- SCT Contributions enrich those SCTs across recursion levels.
- Step V assignments reference actual R0/SIF contributions.
- Communication loops remain explicit.
- S3* remains distinct.
- R0/SIF is the default lens in multi-level views.
- Lower and higher recursion levels remain available.
- Step VII accountability enriches canonical SCTs and Contributions.
- Comparison and Deploy never create disconnected SCT copies.
- The standalone VSM map remains available in addition to its Step V role.

9. Target Viability Review

9.1 Purpose

The Target Viability Review tests the Intended After before the organization authorizes deployment.

It asks:

Is the complete target design internally coherent and plausibly capable of maintaining viability under the relevant variety?

This closes a cybernetic gap between completing individual design steps and committing to intervention.

The Target Viability Review is:

- A concluding Design control.
- Facilitator-led and human interpreted.
- An input to the Transition Decision.

- Not an eighth VSM design step.
- Not an automatic score.
- Not proof that the design will work in practice.

9.2 Review Areas

The review considers:

- System identity and boundary coherence.
- Recursion coherence.
- Viability and autonomy of S1 operative units.
- Manageability and variety balance.
- SCT and SCT Contribution coverage.
- Central/decentral consistency.
- S2 coordination capability.
- S3 control, optimization, and resource relationships.
- S3* independent verification.
- S4 environmental and future intelligence.
- S5 policy, identity, and normative closure.
- Channel capacity and closed-loop communication.
- Accountability and representation.
- Conflicting or overloaded design choices.
- Significant unresolved Findings.
- Known assumptions that can only be tested in deployment.

9.3 Review Outcomes

The outcome may be:

- Suitable for Transition Decision.
- Suitable with explicit conditions.
- Suitable for pilot only.
- Return selected issues to Design.
- Escalate a scope or authority issue.

The review records questions and conditions rather than a completeness percentage.

10. Compare

10.1 Purpose

Compare is the persistent cybernetic comparator. It identifies meaningful differences between:

- Current baseline.
- Intended target.
- Observed result.

It answers:

- What exists today?
- What should exist?
- What has actually been realized?
- What is changing?
- What is staying?
- What is being strengthened?
- What is being introduced?
- What is being retired?
- What remains uncertain?
- What requires deployment action?
- What has produced an unintended effect?

10.2 Comparison Dimensions

Dimension	Before	Intended After	Observed After
Identity and boundary	Current practical boundary	Designed System-in-Focus	Actual operating boundary
Operative units	Existing organization	Selected segmentation	Realized operative structure
Recursion	Current nesting	Intended recursion	Actual decision and accountability levels
Variety	Current pressures and coping	Intended attenuation and amplification	Observed capacity to absorb variety
Critical work	Existing responsibilities	Canonical SCTs	Work actually performed and owned
Decision rights	Current authority	Intended allocation	Decisions actually taken at each level
Coordination	Existing mechanisms	Designed S2 capability	Coordination observed in practice
Control	Existing S3 practices	Intended S3 relationships	Actual resource and performance regulation
Independent verification	Existing S3* capability	Intended assurance channels	Verification operating in practice
Intelligence	Existing S4 capability	Intended environmental connection	Strategic intelligence actually used
Policy and identity	Existing S5 practice	Intended normative closure	Actual policy coherence
Communication	Existing channels	Designed channels and loops	Channels actually used
Representation	Existing roles and meetings	Target accountability	Roles and meetings operating in practice

10.3 Asymmetry

Before and Intended After do not need equal detail.

The current state may legitimately be:

- Informal.
- Unclear.
- Inconsistent.
- Disputed.
- Dependent on individuals.
- Distributed across several mechanisms.
- Unknown.

The target state may be more explicit. This asymmetry prevents Analysis from becoming a complete reverse-engineering exercise.

10.4 Delta Authorship and Timing

At Design close, the facilitator drafts Deltas on the Structural Comparison surface, supported by the locked baseline and canonical target artifacts.

The facilitator authors the comparison but does not unilaterally authorize organizational change. Relevant decision authorities validate Delta dispositions.

The pipeline is:

```
Design closes
-> Facilitator drafts Deltas
-> Relevant authorities set or validate dispositions
-> Stakeholder Impacts are drafted and validated
-> Target Viability Review is resolved
-> Transition Decision selects accepted Deltas for deployment
-> Change Narrative is finalized
-> Deploy begins
```

10.5 Delta Model

Three concerns remain separate.

Change Type

- Keep.
- Strengthen.
- Clarify.
- Change.
- Introduce.
- Retire.

Introduce means that no equivalent baseline reference exists. Retire means that no retained target reference exists.

Disposition

- Proposed.
- Accepted.
- Deferred.
- Rejected.
- Investigating.

A disposition is a human decision. Accepted means the difference is recognized as part of the intended design. It does not by itself authorize immediate deployment.

Deployment Validation

A separate indication records whether the Delta must be validated during deployment. "Validate during Deploy" is not a Change Type.

10.6 Displaced Variety

Every Change or Retire Delta affecting an existing formal or informal mechanism considers:

- Which variety the mechanism currently absorbs.
- Which useful function or compensating capability it provides.
- Where that variety will go after the change.
- What replaces the mechanism, if anything.
- What risk arises if it is removed too early.
- Which observation will show whether the replacement works.

An informal mechanism is not assumed to be waste merely because it is informal. It may be compensating for a missing formal channel or steering capability.

10.7 Decision-Rights Deltas

A Delta that changes decision authority requires confirmation from the holder, grantor, or appropriately authorized representative of that authority.

The facilitator may document and explain the proposed redistribution but cannot authorize it.

If the relevant authority spans several recursion levels, the decision must be confirmed at a level whose mandate covers all affected levels. Otherwise, the Delta is escalated or split into separately authorized decisions.

10.8 Comparison Views

Finding-Level Traceability

Shows:

Finding -> Design Response -> Target Artifact

This is the lightest and earliest useful Compare view.

Structural Comparison

Shows Baseline Statements against canonical target artifacts. Multi-level views default to R0/SIF while allowing explicit access to other recursion levels.

Executive Comparison

Shows the most consequential changes:

- Current tension.
- Target principle.
- Expected effect.
- Affected stakeholders.
- Delta disposition.
- Proposed transition treatment.

The facilitator drafts the Executive Comparison. The sponsor validates and approves it.

Observed-Outcome Comparison

After Deploy, shows:

- Intended effect.
- Observed effect.
- Supporting evidence.
- Remaining gap.
- Required response.

11. Stakeholder Impact and Communication

11.1 Stakeholder Impact

After Design, Deltas can be interpreted as Stakeholder Impacts.

An Impact may describe:

- Current experience.
- Intended future experience.
- What changes.
- What remains unchanged.
- New authority.
- New accountability.
- New expected behavior.
- Affected processes.
- Affected channels.
- Affected meetings.
- Expected benefit.
- Likely concern.
- Timing.
- Participation requirement.

The facilitator drafts Impacts with the affected groups or their legitimate representatives. Affected groups validate whether the description fairly represents the anticipated effect.

Impact assessment remains human-led. VSM7 may suggest connections but does not declare stakeholder consequences automatically.

11.2 Two-Stage Change Narrative

The change narrative develops in two stages.

Analysis Narrative: Why Change?

Derived from:

- Evidence References.
- Findings.
- Viability tensions.
- Existing strengths.
- Consequences.
- Risks of inaction.

Post-Decision Narrative: What Will Change?

Derived from:

- Decision Records originating in Design.
- Accepted Deltas.
- Stakeholder Impacts.
- Transition Decision.
- Deployment sequence.

This prevents Analysis from pretending that the target solution is already known.

11.3 Communication as a Control Relationship

Communication is not merely publication. Cybernetically, it should:

- Convey relevant distinctions.
- Support coordinated action.
- Carry questions and objections back.
- Detect misunderstanding.
- Reveal unexpected variety.
- Trigger adaptation where necessary.

Relevant communication activities therefore allow Stakeholder Responses to become Evidence References.

The loop is:

```
Message
-> Stakeholder interpretation
-> Question, objection, or signal
-> Evidence
-> Finding, Decision, or deployment adjustment
```

11.4 Overall Change Narrative

The Change Narrative explains:

- Why the inquiry began.
- What Analysis found.
- What already works.
- What requires change.
- What the target design should enable.
- Which decisions have been made.
- What remains uncertain.
- How Deploy will proceed.
- How people can participate.
- How feedback will influence the transition.

The facilitator or designated change lead drafts the Change Narrative. Affected groups validate material Impact descriptions. The sponsor approves the organizational message.

11.5 Communication Across the Lifecycle

Mandate

Why are we beginning this inquiry?

Analysis

What are we hearing and observing?

Design

What possibilities and trade-offs are being considered?

Transition Decision

What has been decided, by whom, and under which conditions?

Deploy

What changes for whom, when, and with what support?

Review

What did we observe, what did stakeholders report, and what must be adjusted?

12. Transition Decision

12.1 Status and Purpose

The Transition Decision is a first-class decision surface between Design and Deploy. It is a decision gate, not a lifecycle phase.

Individual accepted Deltas do not constitute a committed transformation program. The Transition Decision determines whether and how the organization will act on the Intended After.

12.2 Decision Outcomes

Possible outcomes include:

- GO.
- Partial GO.
- Pilot first.
- Defer.
- NO-GO.
- Escalate to a higher recursion level.

NO-GO is a valid outcome. A design project may produce valuable understanding even when the organization chooses not to deploy the proposed changes.

12.3 Required Inputs

The Transition Decision considers:

- Mandate and intended effects.
- Need for Change.
- Design Brief.
- Intended After.
- Target Viability Review.
- Accepted and unresolved Deltas.
- Stakeholder Impacts.
- Decision-rights authorization.
- Displaced-variety assessment.

- Transition risks.
- Resource and timing constraints.
- Significant contested Findings.

12.4 Decision Content

The Transition Decision records:

- Decision outcome.
- Named decider.
- Basis of the decider's authority.
- Recursion levels covered by that authority.
- Sponsor sign-off.
- Approved target scope.
- Included accepted Deltas.
- Accepted Deltas not included in the present transition scope.
- Deferred, rejected, or investigating Deltas.
- Deployment waves.
- Budget and timing envelope.
- Intended effects.
- Observable success signals.
- Major constraints.
- Transition risks.
- Review cadence.
- Conditions requiring renewed decision.
- Algedonic thresholds.
- Communication commitment.

12.5 Relationship Between Disposition and Inclusion

Delta disposition and Transition Decision inclusion are different controls.

- **Disposition** states whether a Delta belongs to the intended design.
- **Inclusion** states whether and when an accepted Delta is authorized for realization in the current transition.

An Accepted Delta may be excluded from the current transition wave. Its disposition remains Accepted, but its realization is explicitly deferred. It must not disappear from the comparison.

A Proposed, Investigating, Rejected, or Deferred Delta cannot silently enter a deployment wave. Its disposition must first be resolved by the appropriate authority.

12.6 Authority Boundary

The Transition Decision is valid only where the named decider's authority covers the affected organizational and recursion scope.

If the decision affects authority held at another recursion level, VSM7 should require one of the following conceptual outcomes:

- Obtain the required authorization.
- Split the transition into separately authorized scopes.

- Escalate the decision.
- Defer the affected Deltas.

12.7 Algedonic Conditions

Some transition conditions require immediate escalation rather than waiting for a scheduled review.

Examples include:

- A critical operative capability is disrupted.
- A transition risk exceeds an agreed threshold.
- A key accountability remains unassigned.
- A required communication loop fails.
- The transition creates unacceptable operational overload.
- The System-in-Focus is no longer valid.
- Stakeholder feedback reveals a material misunderstanding or viability risk.

Each significant threshold has a predefined response, such as:

- Notify sponsor.
- Pause a deployment wave.
- Reopen a Decision Record.
- Initiate an independent S3* review.
- Return to Design.
- Escalate to a higher recursion level.

13. Deploy

13.1 Purpose

Deploy answers:

How will the organization move toward the authorized design while remaining viable during the transition?

Deployment is not only project execution. It is the regulated intervention through which the Intended After is tested against organizational reality.

"Deploy" is the phase and navigation label. "Deployment" is the activity and the collective transition work performed within that phase.

13.2 Relationship to Existing Implementation Support

Deploy evolves the existing Implementation area. It does not create:

- A second implementation area.
- A parallel backlog.
- A separate source of truth.
- Duplicated deployment records.

Existing storage and view identities should be evolved or migrated when implementation begins, rather than abandoned in favor of a parallel model.

13.3 Deployment Capabilities

Deploy includes:

- Candidate Inbox.
- Transformation backlog.
- Deployment Items.
- Initiatives and work packages as Deployment Item types.
- Deployment waves.
- Owners.
- Milestones.
- Dependencies.
- Transition risks.
- Pilots and experiments.
- Communication activities.
- Adoption support.
- Review triggers.
- Follow-up decisions.

13.4 Sources of Deployment Work

Deployment candidates may originate from:

- Analysis Finding.
- Decision Record originating in Design.
- Accepted Delta.
- Stakeholder Impact.
- E2E Finding.
- Communication-variety weakness.
- Transition risk.
- Stakeholder Response.
- Review Finding.

Creation of a committed Deployment Item remains an explicit human action through the Candidate Inbox or equivalent triage control.

Every Deployment Item retains its source. If a source later changes or disappears, the item remains and visibly reports that the source is detached.

13.5 Waves and Experiments

The Intended After need not be deployed all at once.

Possible approaches include:

- Pilot within one operative unit.
- Introduce a single communication loop.
- Test revised decision rights.
- Trial a new meeting and agenda structure.
- Establish one S3* verification mechanism.
- Deploy one cluster of related SCT accountabilities.
- Run a limited E2E process experiment.

Pilots and staged waves attenuate transition variety and create early feedback. They do not remove the need for a clear Intended After or explicit authorization.

14. Review

14.1 Purpose

Review closes the organizational control loop.

It asks whether:

- Deployment activity occurred.
- Target capabilities were actually established.
- Intended effects appeared.
- Original Findings improved.
- New tensions emerged.
- The design remains appropriate.
- The baseline should be updated.

14.2 Initiative Review

The Deployment Item owner examines:

- Was the item completed?
- Was it adopted?
- Were milestones met?
- Were dependencies resolved?
- Did the intended local effect occur?
- Which obstacles remain?
- Is further action required?

Completion is not proof of organizational effect.

14.3 System Review

The sponsor and facilitator examine:

- Did the original viability tension improve?
- Can the intended decisions now be taken?
- Has variety moved to a more appropriate level?
- Are operative autonomy and cohesion better balanced?
- Are communication loops functioning?
- Does independent S3* evidence support the reported outcome?
- What do the original stakeholder groups now report?
- Were unintended consequences created?
- Does the design require revision?
- Is a new Analysis cycle required?

System Review uses evidence beyond initiative-owner self-reporting.

Possible sources include:

- Re-interviews.
- Workshop review.
- Observed decisions.
- Meeting records.
- Process evidence.
- Channel use.
- Independent verification.
- Stakeholder Responses.
- Relevant performance signals.

14.4 Review Cadence

The Transition Decision establishes the initial review cadence.

Reviews may be:

- Event-triggered.
- Milestone-based.
- Scheduled after a deployment wave.
- Triggered by an algedonic condition.
- Requested by the sponsor or affected operative units.

14.5 Review Outcomes

A Review may:

- Confirm an intended effect.
- Continue observation.
- Adjust a Deployment Item.
- Add a Deployment Item candidate.
- Reopen a Decision Record.
- Create a new Finding with Review as its phase of origin.
- Re-baseline current reality.
- Begin another lifecycle cycle.
- Escalate to another recursion level.

An Observed Outcome becomes a potential Evidence Reference.

15. Complete Traceability Loop

The canonical reasoning loop is:



This is not a mandatory linear workflow for every artifact.

Examples:

- A Baseline Statement may remain contextual.
- A Finding may not require a Design Response.
- A Decision Record may respond to several Findings.
- One Delta may affect several stakeholder groups.
- A Deployment Item may realize several Deltas.
- An Observed Outcome may challenge the original diagnosis.
- A Finding may point outside the current mandate.
- A Transition Decision may reject, defer, or pilot a proposed change.

Traceability supports professional judgment. It does not replace judgment.

16. Canonical Conceptual Artifacts

Canonical term	Meaning
Mandate	Purpose, scope, reference signals, sponsorship, and intended effects
User Identity	Stable attribution for a person who can be granted scoped platform access
Seat Entitlement	Ceiling on whether a user may receive editing/administrative capability or only view access
Organization Membership	User relationship to an organization and any organization-level administration role
Project Membership	User relationship to a project and its scoped project role
Stakeholder Group	Stable identity for a relevant audience or perspective
Analysis Baseline	Versioned current-state snapshot
Baseline Statement	Addressable statement about current formal or operating reality
Evidence Reference	Relevant source supporting or challenging a statement, Finding, Decision, or Outcome
Finding	Human-authored interpretation; viability tension is a Finding type
Need for Change	Explanation of why intervention should be considered
Design Brief	Questions, hypotheses, constraints, and strengths for Design
Design Response	Link from a Finding to a canonical target artifact
Decision Record	Reasoning and authority behind a consequential choice in any phase
Delta	Meaningful difference between baseline and target
Stakeholder Impact	Consequence of one or more Deltas for a Stakeholder Group
Transition Decision	Authorization, limitation, deferral, pilot, escalation, or rejection of deployment
Deployment Item	Canonical transformation backlog item; initiative and work package are types
Communication Activity	Purposeful message and engagement with a Stakeholder Group
Stakeholder Response	Question, objection, observation, or signal returned through communication
Review	Initiative-level or system-level assessment
Observed Outcome	Review result that may become new evidence

This is a conceptual inventory. It does not require every artifact to have a separate page, dialog, or first-increment implementation.

17. Ownership and Authority

The table below describes method ownership and organizational authority. It does not define software permissions. A user may have permission to prepare or record a Decision without possessing the organizational authority to validate it. Conversely, an authorized sponsor may review through a View Seat without becoming a workshop editor; an in-product approval requires a Full Seat and a separately scoped authority action.

Artifact or action	Drafts or captures	Validates or decides
Mandate	Facilitator with sponsor	Sponsor
Baseline Statements	Facilitator and participants	Relevant participants; facilitator records disputes
Finding	Facilitator or participant	Workshop group or relevant authority; contested status remains possible
Need for Change	Facilitator	Sponsor and relevant stakeholders
Design Brief	Facilitator	Design participants and sponsor as appropriate
Design Response	Facilitator or design participant	Relevant design decision-maker

Artifact or action	Drafts or captures	Validates or decides
Decision Record	Facilitator or decision owner	Named decision authority
Delta	Facilitator	Relevant authority sets or validates disposition
Decision-rights Delta	Facilitator	Holder, grantor, or authorized representative of the authority
Stakeholder Impact	Facilitator with affected group	Affected group validates description
Target Viability Review	Facilitator leads	Design group resolves; sponsor receives conditions
Executive Comparison	Facilitator	Sponsor
Transition Decision	Facilitator prepares	Named decider with sufficient authority; sponsor signs off
Change Narrative	Facilitator or designated change lead	Affected groups validate Impacts; sponsor approves message
Deployment Item	Candidate may come from several sources	Explicit human triage and authorized owner commitment
Initiative Review	Deployment Item owner	Relevant deployment governance
System Review	Facilitator and sponsor	Sponsor or appropriately authorized system leadership
Re-baselining	Facilitator prepares	Sponsor or designated project authority

Ownership may be adapted to context, but authority must not remain implicit where organizational power, accountability, or resource commitments are changed.

Software access, artifact ownership, and organizational decision authority therefore remain three distinct controls:

Access role: What may this user do in VSM7?
 Artifact role: What work is this person expected to prepare or maintain?
 Method authority: What is this person legitimately authorized to decide?

18. Navigation Direction

Access and administration sit outside the VSM lifecycle. They are shown only to users who need them:

Platform Administration	Technical Super-Admin only
Organization Members & Seats	Organization Admin
Project Access	Project Manager and Organization Admin

The project workspace follows the lifecycle:

```

Project Overview

Mandate

Analysis
  Analysis Frame
  Current-State Snapshot
  Findings
  Need for Change
  Design Brief

Design
  I. Operative Units
  II. Manageability
  III. SCTs
  IV. Central / Decentral
  V. Design Steering System
  VI. Channels
  VII. Representation
  Target Viability Review

Compare
  Finding Traceability
  Structural Comparison
  Executive Comparison
  Stakeholder Impacts
  
```

Observed Outcomes

Transition Decision

Deploy

Candidate Inbox
 Transformation Backlog
 Roadmap and Waves
 Owners and Milestones
 Dependencies and Risks
 Communication and Adoption

Review

Initiative Reviews
 System Reviews
 New Evidence and Re-Baselining

VSM Map

The Transition Decision has a visible first-class surface between Compare/Design and Deploy while remaining a gate rather than a phase.

Findings are one cross-phase collection. Analysis is their primary working home, but Findings created during Design, Deploy, or Review remain visible through origin filters and contextual links.

Evidence, Decisions, Traceability, Communication, and Exports may be accessed contextually instead of becoming additional lifecycle phases.

The standalone VSM map remains in navigation in addition to its Step V role.

Viewers see the same project structure and canonical evidence, subject to project scope and any deliberately restricted material. Editing, administration, authorization, and destructive controls are shown according to role. A read-only user is never presented with a misleading editable surface whose changes cannot be retained.

Exports continue through the existing export capability rather than becoming a parallel page or storage system. Potential future export targets include:

- Analysis Summary.
- Need for Change.
- Design Brief.
- Executive Comparison.
- Target Viability Review.
- Transition Decision.
- Change Narrative.
- Deployment Roadmap.
- System Review.

19. User, Seat, and Access Concept

19.1 Purpose

VSM7 needs a user model that is simple enough for workshops and disciplined enough for a professional platform.

It must answer five different questions without collapsing them into one generic role:

1. **Identity:** Who is the person using the platform?
2. **Seat:** What level of product participation has been provisioned for that person?
3. **Organization role:** What may the person administer across one organization?
4. **Project role:** What may the person do in a specific VSM7 project?
5. **Method responsibility and authority:** What is the person expected and legitimately authorized to decide in the organizational inquiry?

The first four are product-access concerns. The fifth belongs to the VSM engagement and may differ by artifact, decision, recursion level, and authority scope.

Access roles such as Project Manager, Facilitator/Editor, and Viewer are platform concepts. They **MUST NOT** be confused with the organizational roles, functions, meetings, and RASIC relationships designed in Step VII.

19.2 Control Principle

The access model follows least privilege and explicit scope:

```
Identity
-> Seat entitlement
-> Organization membership
-> Project membership
-> Permitted product action
```

Method authority follows a separate chain:

```
Mandate
-> Named responsibility
-> Authority scope
-> Decision or validation
-> Decision Record
```

The two chains meet when VSM7 records an authorized action, but they never become interchangeable.

Cybernetically, access management regulates organizational information and action variety. It attenuates access that is irrelevant or unsafe, amplifies the information needed by a participant, and keeps an accountable channel between request, authorization, action, and review.

```
Access need
-> Scoped grant
-> Effective participation
-> Recorded action
-> Access review
-> Retain, change, or revoke
```

The aim is requisite access, not maximum access. Too little access blocks feedback and participation; too much access creates unowned intervention variety and weakens accountability. Platform roles are therefore neither organizational status symbols nor a digital copy of the VSM recursion. In particular, a Technical Super-Admin is not the platform equivalent of System 5.

Examples:

- A Technical Super-Admin may restore service without being allowed to alter a project's VSM design.
- A Project Manager may invite participants and schedule reviews without being authorized to redistribute decision rights.
- A Facilitator may edit a Transition Decision draft without being its authorized decider.

- A sponsor may review through a View Seat. Approval inside VSM7 requires a Full Seat plus an explicitly scoped method action; otherwise an editor records the externally given approval with its evidence.
- A viewer may inspect and export an authorized report without changing canonical project data.

19.3 Seat Types

The initial commercial and product model should remain deliberately small.

Seat type	Product capability	Permitted roles
Full Seat	May administer or edit where a scoped role grants permission	Organization Admin, Project Manager, Facilitator/Editor, Viewer
View Seat	Read-only access to assigned projects	Viewer only

A seat is an entitlement ceiling, not a permission by itself. A Full Seat does not grant access to every organization or project. A View Seat cannot be elevated to an editing role until its entitlement changes.

Additional seat categories should not be introduced until real usage demonstrates a need. Guest, comment-only, external-review, and temporary workshop-participant concepts remain future hypotheses.

19.4 Platform, Organization, and Project Roles

Technical Super-Admin

Scope: platform.

Primary responsibilities:

- Provision and maintain organizations.
- Manage technical platform configuration, security, support, and service recovery.
- Diagnose operational failures and manage platform-level policy.
- View platform health and auditable administrative events.

Boundaries:

- No implicit method authority.
- No default right to edit project content.
- Content access for support should be exceptional, explicit, time-bounded where practical, and auditable.
- A technical action must not silently become a project decision.

Organization Admin

Scope: one organization.

Primary responsibilities:

- Manage organization membership and seat allocation.
- Assign or revoke organization roles.
- Create, archive, or transfer projects according to policy.
- Assign Project Managers.
- Maintain organization-level settings and access policy.

Boundaries:

- No automatic authority over VSM conclusions or transition decisions.
- Project content access should follow explicit project membership unless organization policy deliberately grants administrative visibility.
- Removing membership never deletes authored evidence or historical attribution.

Project Manager

Scope: one or more assigned projects.

Primary responsibilities:

- Manage project membership and project roles.
- Maintain the project frame, lifecycle status, access, review dates, and operational project settings.
- Coordinate archival, transfer, and project-level exports according to policy.
- Ensure that sponsors, facilitators, deciders, and reviewers can access the right surfaces.

Boundaries:

- Does not automatically become a VSM facilitator or content editor.
- Does not automatically authorize the Need for Change, target design, decision-rights Deltas, or Transition Decision.
- Cannot exceed the seat and organization policy assigned to another member.

Facilitator/Editor

Scope: assigned projects.

Primary responsibilities:

- Capture, structure, and refine canonical workshop data.
- Facilitate Analysis, Design, Compare, Deploy, and Review work.
- Prepare Findings, Decision Records, Deltas, reports, and decision materials.
- Promote candidates through explicit human actions where the method permits it.

Boundaries:

- Editing permission does not imply organizational decision authority.
- Consequential validation remains attributed to the named sponsor, decider, or relevant authority.
- Destructive actions remain confirmed even when the user has editing permission.

Viewer / View Seat

Scope: assigned projects.

Primary capabilities:

- Navigate the project and its lifecycle surfaces.
- Read canonical artifacts, provenance, decisions, and authorized comparisons.
- Use filters, scope controls, focus/fullscreen, and presentation views without mutating project data.
- Receive or generate exports where project policy permits.

Boundaries:

- Cannot create, edit, delete, accept, merge, promote, re-baseline, or change project membership.
- A View Seat cannot authorize. A Full-Seat Viewer may perform only a separately granted, method-scoped approval action.
- Personal display state such as the currently selected item may remain local and must not change canonical data.
- Restricted or draft material remains subject to explicit project policy; read-only does not necessarily mean read-everything.

19.5 Permission Matrix

The initial model should use a compact, understandable matrix rather than per-field permission configuration.

Capability	Super-Admin	Org Admin	Project Manager	Facilitator/Editor	Viewer
Manage platform configuration	Yes	No	No	No	No
Create/manage organizations	Yes	No	No	No	No
Manage organization members and seats	Support only	Yes	No	No	No
Create/archive/transfer projects	Policy/support	Yes	Assigned scope	No	No
Manage project members and roles	Support only	Yes	Yes	No	No
Edit canonical project content	No by default	Explicit membership	Explicit editor role	Yes	No
Prepare decisions and reports	No by default	Explicit membership	If editor role	Yes	No
Validate method decisions	Only if separately named	Only if separately named	Only if separately named	Only if separately named	Full Seat plus a separately named scoped action only
View assigned project	Exceptional support	According to policy	Yes	Yes	Yes
Export assigned content	Exceptional support	According to policy	According to policy	According to policy	According to policy

"Support only" means an auditable exceptional operation, not routine project membership.

The Viewer column describes the Viewer project role. A View Seat receives that role in strict read-only form; a Full-Seat Viewer may additionally receive a single scoped approval action when method authority has been separately recorded.

19.6 Method Responsibilities Are Not Access Roles

VSM7 may name method responsibilities such as:

- Sponsor.
- Facilitator.
- Analysis participant.
- Design participant.
- Decision owner.
- Transition decider.
- Deployment Item owner.
- Reviewer.
- Evidence provider.
- Affected stakeholder representative.

These describe responsibility in the inquiry. They may be held by users with different product roles.

The Transition Decision must still record:

- The named decider.
- The authority scope.
- Any conditions or limits.
- The decision date.
- The relationship to sponsor sign-off.

No combination of Super-Admin, Organization Admin, or Project Manager permissions may silently satisfy this method requirement.

19.7 Membership and Access Lifecycle

The basic lifecycle is:

```
Invite or provision
-> Assign seat
-> Add to organization
-> Add to project
-> Assign project role
-> Review or change access
-> Revoke or transfer
```

Required controls:

- Invitations identify organization, project, proposed role, inviter, and expiry where applicable.
- Users see only organizations and projects to which they have access.
- Role changes are explicit and auditable.
- Seat downgrade cannot leave an impossible editing assignment; conflicts must be resolved visibly.
- Removing project access preserves authored content, comments, decisions, evidence, and attribution.
- Removing an Organization Admin or Project Manager requires transfer of responsibilities where needed.
- Deactivation prevents new access while preserving historical identity.
- Project archival makes content read-only unless restored by an authorized user.
- Access removal and administrative deletion require confirmation naming the user and affected scope.

19.8 Minimum Management Surfaces

The user-management experience should remain small and legible.

Platform organizations

Visible only to Technical Super-Admins. It shows:

- Organization name and status.
- Assigned Organization Admins.
- Seat allocation or agreed capacity.
- Relevant platform-access state.
- Exceptional support access and its expiry.

It supports provisioning, suspension, recovery, and audited support actions. It does not expose routine project editing.

Organization members and seats

Visible to Organization Admins. One member table shows:

- Person and invitation status.
- Seat type.
- Organization role.
- Number of assigned projects.
- Access state.
- Compact actions for invite, assign, transfer, deactivate, or remove.

The surface must expose seat conflicts and unassigned responsibilities directly. It should not require a separate configuration page for every user.

Project access

Visible to Project Managers and Organization Admins. One project-level surface shows:

- Member.
- Project role.
- Seat compatibility.
- Named method responsibilities such as sponsor, facilitator, decider, owner, or reviewer.
- Invitation or access status.
- Effective access summary.

Adding a person should follow select existing organization member -> assign project role -> optionally record method responsibility. Creating a new invitation is the fallback when the person does not yet exist.

My access

Every user can inspect:

- Their seat type.
- Organization and project memberships.
- Effective role in the current project.
- Any explicitly named method responsibilities.
- Who can change their access.

This makes access understandable without exposing a complex permission editor.

19.9 Read-Only and Approval Experience

Read-only must feel intentional, not broken.

- The project clearly identifies read-only status without repeating a warning in every tile.
- Editing and destructive controls are omitted where they would create noise or false expectation.
- View controls remain available: filters, drill-down, scope, focus/fullscreen, comparison lenses, and permitted export.
- Data-entry fields render as readable content, not as disabled grey form controls wherever practical.
- A Full-Seat Viewer who is separately named as a method authority may receive one scoped approval action without receiving general editing. A View Seat remains strictly read-only.
- The approval surface shows the exact object, version, evidence, implications, and recorded authority.

19.10 Audit, Attribution, and Privacy

Every consequential action should retain:

- Stable user identity.
- Timestamp.
- Organization and project scope.
- Action type.
- Affected artifact or membership.
- Previous and resulting state where relevant.
- Acting role and, for method decisions, named authority basis.

The audit trail supports accountability and recovery. It is not a surveillance dashboard and should expose only information relevant to project governance and platform security.

Technical support access to project content is especially sensitive. It should be visible, justified, limited, and recorded. Public anonymous project links are out of scope for the baseline concept.

19.11 Incremental Introduction

The final access concept may require shared identity, invitation, and persistence services beyond the current browser-local product boundary. That architectural implication is acknowledged but not prematurely solved in this document.

A credible progression is:

1. Define role vocabulary, project membership, and role-sensitive read-only behavior.
2. Introduce shared identity and organization membership when multi-user persistence is available.
3. Add invitations, seat administration, project-role assignment, and auditable access changes.
4. Add exceptional technical-support access and finer project policies only when operational evidence requires them.

VSM7 must not introduce a required Node.js backend merely to imitate multi-user administration before the platform has a deliberate shared-service architecture. The conceptual access model is stable direction; its technical realization is an incremental product-development decision.

20. UX/UI Contract

20.1 Status and Purpose

This chapter consolidates the settled UX/UI principles from prior VSM7 design and implementation briefings. It is a product contract for future lifecycle development, not a screen-by-screen design specification.

The contract protects four things:

1. Method integrity.
2. Live-workshop usability.
3. Canonical-data coherence.
4. Honest human judgment.

MUST denotes a non-negotiable product behavior. SHOULD denotes the expected default unless a documented context justifies another treatment. Exact spacing, wording, and visual composition may evolve through design and user evidence.

20.2 Audience and Operating Context

VSM7 is a workshop cockpit for VSM experts. It MUST support:

- Live capture by a facilitator.
- Collaborative examination on a projected or shared screen.
- Focused design work by one or more editors.
- Review by sponsors, deciders, stakeholders, and View Seats.
- Follow-up work in the same canonical project.

The interface MUST NOT teach basic VSM theory at the expense of working space. Short explanations may orient a workshop moment, but the primary surface is the work itself.

Every major capability SHOULD be evaluated in two modes:

Mode	Purpose	Characteristics
Capture mode	Enter, edit, reconcile, and inspect structured data	Denser forms, tables, matrices, inspectors, rapid interaction
Facilitation/focus mode	Explain, compare, decide, and review with a group	Larger type, stronger contrast, fewer words, visible outcomes and prompts

Focus mode uses the same canonical data as capture mode. It is a different rendering, not a copied presentation artifact.

20.3 Information Architecture and Context

- The product **MUST** preserve the hierarchy Organization -> Project -> Lifecycle/Steps -> Canonical artifacts -> Exports.
- The start page **MUST** remain organization/project oriented and **MUST NOT** show project-only left navigation before a project is open.
- Project Overview **SHOULD** be a read-mostly lifecycle dashboard, not a competing editing surface.
- Lifecycle phases, the seven VSM Design steps, gates, and cross-phase capabilities **MUST** remain visually distinguishable.
- Compare, Evidence, Decisions, Traceability, Communication, and Exports **MUST NOT** masquerade as additional VSM steps.
- Access-administration surfaces **MUST** sit outside the method lifecycle and appear only to relevant roles.
- R0, the System-in-Focus, **MUST** be the default lens whenever several recursion levels are available.
- R-1 and R+1 **MUST** remain accessible through an explicit scope or level control.
- Recursion levels **MUST** remain visibly grouped and **MUST NOT** be flattened into an undifferentiated list.
- The current organization, project, lifecycle phase, recursion lens, selected SCT, and other scope-defining context **SHOULD** remain visible through stable headings, breadcrumbs, sticky context, or equivalent orientation.

20.4 Canonical Identity, Reuse, and Provenance

- Every cross-step entity **MUST** have a stable identity independent of its mutable name.
- Relationships **MUST** reference canonical entities, not copied labels or duplicate records.
- The interface **MUST** display readable names and display ids; internal ids appear only where needed for diagnosis or export fidelity.
- Selection controls **MUST** prefer existing canonical entities before offering creation of a new one.
- Derived candidates **MUST** show their provenance and remain distinct from accepted human-authored content.
- Suggested, inherited, and locally authored content **MUST** be visually distinguishable where that difference matters.
- Regeneration after an upstream change **MUST** show what would be added, changed, detached, or preserved.
- Human-authored content **MUST** never be silently overwritten by derived content.
- Renames **MUST** resolve live through stable references.
- Removed sources **MUST** leave dependent evidence visible as detached or unavailable rather than deleting it silently.

20.5 Workshop Capture and Editing

- Immediate capture **MUST** be brief, forgiving, and possible without completing every enrichment field.
- Enrichment **SHOULD** be available inline, in an inspector, or through a visible follow-up queue.
- Unknown, Contested, Not yet assessed, and Not relevant states **MUST** be representable without manufactured certainty.
- Empty content **MUST** remain honestly empty; the product **MUST NOT** invent placeholder conclusions or candidate SCTs unsupported by workshop data.
- Forms **MUST** use the control that matches the decision: checkboxes/toggles for binary settings, segmented controls for small modes, menus for option sets, and inputs/sliders/steppers for numeric values.
- Tables and matrices **MUST** preserve headers and scope while scrolling where loss of context would be costly.

- Repeated complex items SHOULD use a list-and-inspector or matrix-and-inspector pattern instead of wide collections of nested forms.
- Creating or selecting an item SHOULD preserve the user's viewport and relevant internal scroll position.
- In-place add, edit, select, split, merge, and remove actions MUST NOT return the facilitator to the top of the page.
- Fast workshop capture SHOULD be inline or anchored near the selected content. Modal flows SHOULD be reserved for consequential decisions, multi-step tasks, or confirmation.
- No step or project completeness percentage may be calculated, displayed, or exported.

20.6 Controls and Action Economy

- Each function MUST have one visible primary control within a content unit.
- The host and an embedded component MUST NOT expose duplicate controls for the same action.
- Icon buttons MUST use familiar symbols and provide accessible names and tooltips where the meaning is not self-evident.
- Text buttons SHOULD be reserved for clear commands whose meaning benefits from a label.
- Buttons MUST remain compact, stable in size, and visibly button-like.
- Fixed toolbars, board controls, icon clusters, counters, and tiles MUST have stable dimensions so dynamic content does not shift the layout.
- An action SHOULD appear at the smallest meaningful scope: item actions on items, tile actions on tiles, project actions in project-level menus.
- Secondary and infrequent commands SHOULD use a contextual or More menu rather than expanding every surface.
- The latest export grammar is tile/micro-content level plus a project-level export under More; duplicate step-level, host-level, and embedded export controls are not permitted.
- Where a tile supports both export and focus/fullscreen, the expected compact pair is one export control and one focus/fullscreen control.

20.7 Viewport, Focus, Fullscreen, and Canvas

- Fullscreen belongs to a specific matrix, map, chart, editor, or facilitation tile. The obsolete global fullscreen deck MUST NOT return.
- Escape MUST exit focus/fullscreen.
- Entering and leaving focus mode MUST preserve the selected artifact and restore the relevant normal-view position.
- Fullscreen MUST render the same canonical data with presentation-appropriate density and scale.
- Explanation tiles SHOULD contain a strong title, one concise explanatory sentence, an outcome, three guiding prompts, and an optional quiet coach note.
- Canvas tools MUST use the available viewport as working space and MUST NOT sit inside decorative nested cards.
- Established canvas tools SHOULD provide Full/Fit behavior, pan, zoom, and reset where the domain requires spatial navigation.
- A canvas selection SHOULD open properties near the selection or in a stable inspector without obscuring the object being edited.
- Zoom and pan MUST NOT change canonical method data.
- Embedded frames that support browser fullscreen MUST be granted fullscreen permission, and the user-facing fullscreen control MUST remain reliable under browser gesture rules.

20.8 Diagnostics, Uncertainty, and Human Judgment

- Automated calculations MAY expose structural facts, missing references, duplicates, crossings, weak ratings, or unresolved mappings.
- The product MUST NOT present an algorithmic inference as organizational truth.
- Warnings MUST state what was observed and invite a human decision.
- Warnings MUST NOT become hidden completion scoring.
- A diagnostic SHOULD provide a direct path to the relevant artifact or decision surface while preserving context.
- Acceptance, rejection, promotion, authorization, re-baselining, and creation of deployment work MUST require explicit human action.
- Potential remedies SHOULD be framed as hypotheses or options until ratified.
- Color MUST be paired with text, symbol, shape, or pattern wherever meaning would otherwise depend on color alone.

20.9 Required States

Every substantial surface MUST deliberately design at least these states where applicable:

State	Required behavior
Empty	Explain the immediate next action without inventing data or showing an oversized placeholder
Loading	Preserve stable layout and context; avoid page jumps
Saving/pending	Show correlated progress without blocking unrelated reading
Saved	Confirm quietly; do not steal focus
Error	Name the failed action, preserve user input, and offer a recovery path
Read-only	Render legible content and omit misleading edit controls
Unknown/contested	Keep uncertainty visible and attributable
Detached source	Preserve the dependent artifact and identify the missing source
Stale/changed upstream	Show affected references and require reconciliation where needed
Archived	Prevent mutation while preserving navigation, history, and permitted export

Async operations such as exports MUST correlate progress and results to the initiating request. A late response MUST NOT be attached to the wrong tile or selection.

20.10 Keyboard, Accessibility, and Input Equivalence

- All essential actions MUST be operable without hover.
- Keyboard accelerators MAY improve speed but MUST NOT be the only path.
- Single-key shortcuts MUST be ignored while the user is typing in an input, text area, editable region, or relevant selection control.
- Native semantic controls and correct labels SHOULD be preferred over simulated controls.
- Focus indication MUST remain visible.
- Dragging MUST have a click, keyboard, or menu alternative.
- Reversible spatial moves SHOULD provide Undo.
- Projected facilitation controls MUST have sufficiently large targets and contrast for distance use.
- Text MUST fit its container across supported desktop and mobile widths and MUST NOT overlap adjacent controls or content.
- Text size MUST respond through deliberate layout breakpoints or container constraints, not viewport-width font scaling.

- Essential information **MUST** remain available to assistive technology when panels, tabs, or disclosure controls are used.

20.11 Visual Language and Skins

- The product name appears as VSM7.
- The visual character **MUST** be a serious, focused workshop cockpit rather than a generic enterprise form system or decorative marketing site.
- Page sections **SHOULD** be unframed layouts or full-width bands. Cards are for genuinely bounded tools, repeated items, and dialogs, and **MUST NOT** be nested inside other cards.
- Normal step pages **SHOULD** retain a strong workshop stage without oversized sparse heroes.
- Workshop remains the calm, bright default skin.
- Command Deck remains the high-contrast segmented alternative.
- Skins **MUST** use shared presentation tokens and **MUST NOT** duplicate page markup or alter canonical data, scoring, exports, or method logic.
- The color grammar remains: blue for VSM steering and control logic, green/teal for viable or robust states, amber for tension and prioritization, and red for risk, overload, or weak conditions.
- The VSM diagram preserves its specific system grammar: S1 neutral/navy, S2 amber, S3 and S3* red, S4 green, and S5 light blue.
- Method-specific visuals **MUST** explain actual structure, flow, comparison, or workshop state. Generic decoration, decorative blobs, and irrelevant stock imagery do not belong in the work surface.

20.12 Export Contract

- Canonical data remains in VSM7; exported files are generated outcomes.
- Export **MUST** be a pure read operation and **MUST NOT** mutate canonical or presentation state.
- The user **MUST** choose a real deliverable format such as PDF, DOCX, XLSX, PPTX, CSV, PNG, or SVG only when that format is genuinely supported for the artifact.
- The interface **MUST NOT** offer purpose presets that silently substitute one format for another.
- Export options **MUST** appear only when relevant source data exists.
- An export **MUST** identify its artifact, scope, project, relevant baseline/version, and generation time where appropriate.
- Human decisions, uncertainty, source detachment, and provenance **MUST** remain visible in exports when they are material to interpretation.
- Facilitation views and formal exports may render the same data differently, but neither becomes a second source of truth.
- Project-level export remains an explicit project action; local tile export remains scoped to the visible artifact or tool.

20.13 Embedded Tools and Overlay Contract

VSM7 uses code-native embedded tools for complex visuals and editors. Their relationship to the host follows these rules:

- The host owns canonical project identity, persistence, access control, export orchestration, and cross-step context.
- The embedded tool owns its local rendering and interaction model within the agreed boundary.
- Standalone use **MUST** remain safe when no host is present.
- Context exchange **MUST** use stable ids and explicit versioned commands/events rather than scraping visible labels.
- Host-fed data **MUST** remain distinguishable from tool-authored local data.
- Embedded chrome **MUST** hide actions already supplied by the host.

- The host **MUST** assign definite width and height and react to container resize.
- Fullscreen-capable frames **MUST** include the required browser permission.
- Skin changes **MUST** be visual-only and pass through an explicit bridge.
- The host **MUST** wait for readiness or otherwise use a handshake that prevents lost initialization.

For Safari-stable focus overlays, an inactive embedded frame **MUST** remain layout-capable while being non-visible and non-interactive. The established pattern uses hidden visibility, disabled pointer events, and off-screen positioning rather than `display:none`. On opening, the host pins the live pixel dimensions, reveals the frame, forces layout, and re-synchronizes after resize. This is an implementation-facing UX constraint because blank or mis-sized workshop canvases are unacceptable.

20.14 Destructive Actions, Reconciliation, and Undo

- Every destructive action **MUST** ask for explicit confirmation immediately before execution.
- The confirmation **MUST** name the affected artifact, user, project, organization, or scope where available.
- A deletion **MUST** explain material downstream effects before confirmation.
- Referenced canonical data **MUST NOT** be silently cascaded away.
- Split, merge, move, and source-removal operations **MUST** preserve or explicitly reconcile downstream evidence.
- An invertible, local move need not require confirmation when immediate Undo is available.
- Administrative removal of a user **MUST** preserve authored content and historical attribution.
- A rejected candidate may leave provenance; rejection is not equivalent to erasing history.

20.15 Lifecycle-Specific UX Requirements

Surface	Minimum UX requirement
Mandate	A concise reference frame with sponsor, scope, intended effects, uncertainty, and visible authority
Analysis	Rapid Finding capture, progressive enrichment, evidence links, unknown/contested states, and a lean baseline synopsis
Design I-VII	Step-specific visual and editing patterns over one canonical SCT/contribution spine, with R0 default and explicit recursive navigation
Target Viability Review	Facilitation-grade integrated review that exposes tensions and conditions without inventing a score
Compare	Side-by-side or linked Before/Intended After/Observed After views with asymmetric evidence made explicit
Stakeholder Impact	Delta-derived impact views grouped by stakeholder, with validation and disagreement visible
Transition Decision	A focused decision surface showing scope, Deltas, evidence, conditions, authority, and explicit outcome
Deploy	Candidate inbox, backlog, roadmap/waves, owner and dependency views, and visible source traceability
Review	Initiative and system lenses, Observed Outcomes, independent evidence, and direct creation of new Findings
User management	Simple member/seat/role tables, explicit scope, invitation status, role-sensitive controls, confirmations, and audit visibility

20.16 Verification and Acceptance

Future increments **MUST** be reviewed in realistic scenarios, not only by reading specifications.

Minimum acceptance evidence **SHOULD** include:

- Live-workshop walkthroughs with facilitator-paced capture.
- Projected-screen review for distance reading.
- Viewer and approval walkthroughs using non-editor roles.

- R0 default and cross-recursion navigation checks.
- Viewport and internal-scroll continuity after in-place actions.
- Empty, loading, error, read-only, detached, and archived states.
- Keyboard and non-drag alternatives for essential actions.
- Export scope, format, provenance, and non-mutation checks.
- Fullscreen/focus entry, Escape exit, restoration, and embedded-frame resizing.
- Responsive checks for text fit, control overlap, and canvas framing.
- Browser checks including Safari behavior for embedded overlays.
- Confirmation and downstream-impact checks for destructive actions.

20.17 Non-Negotiable Summary

The future VSM7 experience must remain:

- Canonical rather than duplicated.
- Workshop-first rather than administration-first.
- Recursive rather than flattened.
- Human-authorized rather than algorithmically asserted.
- Traceable rather than opaque.
- Focused rather than control-heavy.
- Readable in capture, facilitation, and view-only contexts.
- Honest about uncertainty, provenance, and incremental product maturity.

21. Incremental Product Development

21.1 The Concept Is a Direction, Not a Delivery Promise

This document describes a coherent long-term model. It does not imply that:

- Every artifact must be implemented immediately.
- The initial data model will never change.
- Every proposed interaction will work in practice.
- The complete lifecycle can be designed without workshop feedback.
- Later increments should be predetermined in detail.

VSM7 will move toward this direction through product increments.

Each increment should:

- Deliver independent user value.
- Preserve existing canonical data.
- Avoid parallel sources of truth.
- Produce evidence from real workshop use.
- Leave room for correction.
- Support later extension without implementing speculative complexity.

21.2 Product Development as a Control Loop

The product journey follows the same logic advocated for organizational work:


```
Product intention
-> Small implementation
-> Real workshop use
-> Observation
-> Product Finding
-> Product Decision
-> Next increment
```

The Concept is a reference condition. It guides development while remaining open to evidence.

21.3 Proposed Increment Sequence

Increment 1: Lean Analysis Foundation

Potential scope:

- Mandate extension.
- Analysis Frame.
- Lean Current-State Snapshot.
- Fast Finding capture.
- Finding enrichment.
- Agreed and Contested statuses.
- Need for Change.
- Design Brief.
- Baseline acceptance and date.
- Initial Finding-to-Design Response.
- Evolution of the Implementation label toward Deploy.
- Foundational access vocabulary and role-sensitive read-only behavior.

This increment creates immediate workshop value without requiring the complete Delta model.

Increment 2: Traceability and Transition Control

Potential scope:

- Design Responses on relevant design surfaces.
- Finding-level Compare view.
- Lightweight Decision Records.
- Baseline versioning.
- Target Viability Review.
- First-class Transition Decision.
- Additional deployment source types.
- Candidate Inbox integration.
- Project membership and scoped project-role administration where shared identity is available.

This increment connects Analysis to Design and prevents Deploy from becoming a disconnected backlog.

Increment 3: Structural Comparison

Potential scope:

- Formal Delta model.
- Delta authorship and authority controls.
- Before / Intended After comparison.

- Change Type, disposition, and validation.
- Displaced-variety assessment.
- Baseline-to-canonical-artifact references.
- Structural and Executive comparison views.
- Baseline age and re-baseline warnings.

This is likely the most structurally demanding increment and should build on evidence from the earlier traceability capability.

Increment 4: Stakeholder Impact and Communication

Potential scope:

- Canonical Stakeholder Groups.
- Stakeholder Impact assessment.
- Change Narrative.
- Audience-specific communication.
- Stakeholder Response capture.
- Feedback into Evidence and Findings.

This increment turns communication from one-way publication into a feedback relationship.

It may also introduce controlled View Seats for sponsors, affected stakeholders, and reviewers if the shared platform foundation is ready.

Increment 5: Review and Recursive Learning

Potential scope:

- Initiative Review.
- System Review.
- Independent verification support.
- Observed After comparison.
- Review-triggered Findings.
- Re-baselining.
- Algedonic thresholds and predefined responses.
- New-cycle initiation.

This closes the complete organizational control loop.

21.4 Sequencing Is Provisional

The proposed increments are hypotheses. They should change when evidence shows that:

- Facilitators need a different sequence.
- A supposedly simple artifact creates workshop friction.
- Users derive more value from another capability.
- Existing product structures support a faster route.
- A planned abstraction is unnecessary.
- New methodical risks become visible.

The development roadmap is reviewed rather than treated as immutable.

21.5 Foundational Choices Versus Deferred Sophistication

Some decisions must be protected from the first increment because later correction would be costly:

- One canonical project rather than separate Before and After workspaces.
- Stable identities for referenced artifacts.
- Findings as a cross-phase collection.
- Explicit phase of origin.
- Human authorization for organizational conclusions and actions.
- Separation of Intended After and Observed After.
- Source retention for Deployment Items.
- Separation of software permissions, artifact responsibilities, and method authority.
- Stable user attribution even after access is revoked.

Other elements can remain deliberately simple until evidence justifies more sophistication:

- Detailed dashboarding.
- Automated comparison suggestions.
- Rich evidence management.
- Advanced communication planning.
- Complex review scheduling.
- Universal presentation generation.
- Cross-project recursion support.
- Fine-grained permissions beyond the compact role model.
- Guest, comment-only, public-link, and temporary-seat variants.
- Advanced organization policy and identity-provider integration.

22. Primary Risks and Guardrails

Risk	Guardrail
Analysis becomes too heavy	Lean baseline, capture-first Findings, explicit scope, facilitator-controlled sufficiency
Analysis pre-commits Design	Design questions and hypotheses; explicit Design Responses and decisions
Before becomes a duplicate workspace	Lean baseline in the same project; canonical target references
Target is mistaken for reality	Distinguish Intended After from Observed After
Baseline silently decays	Show baseline version and age; explicit re-baselining
Compare becomes a static presentation	Link Findings, target artifacts, Impacts, Decisions, and Deployment Items
Informal coping is removed blindly	Require displaced-variety assessment for Change and Retire Deltas
Facilitator appears to redistribute power	Require authorization for decision-rights Deltas and Transition Decision scope
Communication becomes one-way broadcasting	Capture Stakeholder Responses and return them as Evidence
Review relies on owner self-reporting	Include System Review and independent S3* verification
Evidence becomes a document repository	Store or reference only evidence relevant to a project distinction
Lifecycle becomes a waterfall	Allow Findings, Decisions, Reviews, and evidence to reopen earlier work
VSM becomes generic change management	Preserve System-in-Focus, recursion, variety, S1-S5, S3*, channels, autonomy, and algedonic escalation

Risk	Guardrail
VSM terminology slows workshop capture	Rapid plain-language capture with systemic enrichment later
Product scope expands too quickly	Build useful increments and let workshop evidence shape subsequent work
Software permission is mistaken for decision authority	Keep access role, artifact role, and method authority explicit and separately attributed
View Seats create accidental mutation paths	Render intentional read-only surfaces and verify every state-changing action by role
Super-Admin becomes an invisible content owner	Make support access exceptional, scoped, justified, and auditable
Removing a user removes project history	Preserve stable attribution and transfer responsibilities without deleting authored content
User management overwhelms workshop work	Keep two seat types, a compact role matrix, and role-sensitive administration outside the lifecycle
Multi-user ambition distorts the current runtime boundary	Treat shared identity and persistence as a deliberate later platform increment, not an incidental backend addition
UX contracts fragment across embedded tools	Use one host/component boundary, one action per function, stable ids, and scenario-based verification
Read-only users receive disabled editor clutter	Render purpose-built readable views and omit controls that cannot be used

23. Decisions Established by Concept 1.0

Concept 1.0 establishes the following directional decisions:

1. VSM7 uses the lifecycle phases Mandate, Analysis, Design, Deploy, and Review.
2. Compare is a persistent cross-phase capability, not a VSM method phase.
3. Before, Intended After, and Observed After are distinct organizational states.
4. Analysis remains deliberately lean and does not duplicate the seven Design steps.
5. Need for Change is an Analysis outcome.
6. Concrete Stakeholder Impacts are derived after target design through comparison.
7. The current-state baseline exists inside the same canonical project and is versioned.
8. Important Findings connect to target artifacts through lightweight Design Responses.
9. Target Viability Review checks the complete Intended After before transition authorization.
10. The Transition Decision is a first-class decision gate between Design and Deploy.
11. Delta authorship, disposition, deployment inclusion, and authority are distinct concerns.
12. Change and Retire Deltas account for displaced variety and existing compensating mechanisms.
13. Decision-rights changes require appropriate authority.
14. Deploy evolves the existing Implementation area and does not create a parallel backlog.
15. Communication includes Stakeholder Response and operates as a feedback relationship.
16. Review is divided into Initiative Review and System Review.
17. Observed Outcomes become potential new Evidence References.
18. Only observed and deliberately accepted reality may become the next baseline.
19. Findings form one cross-phase collection with phase-of-origin information.
20. The concept is developed incrementally and revised through product and workshop evidence.
21. The seven VSM steps are the explicit, recursive core of Design and jointly produce the Intended After.
22. VSM7 distinguishes identity, seat, organization role, project role, artifact responsibility, and method authority.

23. The initial seat model uses Full Seats and View Seats with a compact scoped role model.
24. Technical Super-Admin access does not imply project-content access or method authority.
25. Read-only participation is a deliberate product experience, not a disabled editor.
26. Prior VSM7 UX decisions are consolidated into one future-facing UX/UI contract.
27. Canonical reuse, stable identity, provenance, human ratification, viewport continuity, local focus/fullscreen, and non-duplicated controls are protected product behaviors.

These are conceptual product decisions. They do not imply that every supporting artifact or interaction ships in Increment 1.

24. Open Product Hypotheses

The following remain product hypotheses to be tested rather than frozen requirements:

- The best number and arrangement of Analysis capture surfaces.
- The minimum Finding fields required during live capture.
- Whether Finding enrichment is performed in a dedicated inbox or contextually.
- The right amount of VSM terminology during initial capture.
- Whether baseline locking is a formal workshop event or a quieter project action.
- Which Design surfaces need Design Response controls first.
- How much Delta drafting can be suggested without undermining human judgment.
- The most useful first comparison view.
- The right visual form for the Target Viability Review.
- How stakeholder validation is recorded without creating administrative overload.
- Which Review signals are qualitative, quantitative, or mixed.
- How linked projects across recursion levels should eventually work.
- Which shared identity and persistence architecture best preserves VSM7's browser-shareable character.
- Whether organizations need private projects, organization-visible projects, or only explicit project membership.
- Whether View Seats may export by default or only when a Project Manager enables it.
- Whether the strict read-only boundary of View Seats should ever be extended for comments or narrowly scoped acknowledgements.
- Whether comments or review notes justify a future comment-only role.
- Which audit events must be visible to project users, organization admins, and technical support.
- Whether temporary external access is required and how it expires.
- Whether enterprise identity-provider integration is needed before or after the core shared-user model.

These hypotheses belong to the product development loop and should be resolved through incremental use.

25. Final Review Guide

This version incorporates the six precision corrections identified in the preceding external review and adds three areas that required stronger treatment:

1. Transition Decision now has a first-class surface and an unambiguous status as a gate rather than a phase.
2. Delta authorship, timing, and validating authority are explicit.
3. Delta disposition, Stakeholder Impact, Transition Decision inclusion, and Change Narrative follow one defined sequence.
4. An integrative Target Viability Review tests the Intended After before GO.
5. Displaced variety and decision-rights authority are explicit controls.
6. Canonical vocabulary, cross-phase Finding ownership, artifact authorship, and the Evidence boundary are reconciled.
7. The seven-step VSM Design Phase is now specified as the methodical center that creates the Intended After.
8. Prior UX/UI decisions are consolidated into a precise future product contract.
9. User, seat, access, artifact responsibility, and organizational authority are explicitly separated.

The final reviewer is asked to verify:

- Is the control loop cybernetically closed?
- Is the distinction between Before, Intended After, and Observed After consistent throughout?
- Is the Target Viability Review sufficiently VSM-specific without becoming Step VIII?
- Is the Transition Decision correctly positioned and authorized?
- Is the Delta pipeline free of circular dependencies?
- Is displaced variety considered before informal mechanisms are removed?
- Are decision-rights changes protected by appropriate authority?
- Is the vocabulary internally consistent?
- Does Analysis remain lean enough for live workshops?
- Does the incremental development path distinguish foundations from deferred sophistication?
- Does any remaining part of the concept imply that the full model must be implemented at once?
- Are all seven Design steps sufficiently explicit, connected, recursive, and faithful to the canonical SCT backbone?
- Does the UX/UI contract protect workshop speed, facilitation quality, canonical data, provenance, and human judgment?
- Is the Full Seat/View Seat model simple enough while supporting Super-Admin, Organization Admin, Project Manager, Facilitator/Editor, and Viewer needs?
- Is the boundary between software permission and legitimate organizational authority unambiguous?
- Does the user model acknowledge the future shared-platform requirement without prematurely dictating its architecture?

26. Final Position

The intended evolution of VSM7 is:

Mandate establishes the reference.

Analysis observes and interprets the current system.

Design creates an Intended After through VSM Steps I-VII.

Target Viability Review tests the design as a coherent viable system.

Compare makes meaningful differences visible.

Transition Decision selects and authorizes a response.

Deploy intervenes in organizational reality.

Review observes the effects.

Observed effects become new evidence.

The organization and the product learn through repeated cycles.

VSM7 should not promise to engineer an organization from a perfect model.

It should help VSM experts maintain a coherent chain from evidence to diagnosis, from diagnosis to design, from design to authorized intervention, and from intervention back to evidence.

It should make that chain available to the right people with the least access they need: administrators who can operate the platform, Project Managers who can govern participation, facilitators who can shape the canonical workshop record, authorized deciders who can validate consequential choices, and View Seats who can understand the work without accidentally changing it.

The same humility applies to VSM7 itself. Concept 1.0 establishes direction and protects important method boundaries. Its quality will ultimately be determined increment by increment through real workshops, critical review, and continued learning.